

Low Preference for Shy Peers in China: Increasing Context Sensitivity from Preschool to Adolescence



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Background

- Shyness predicts peer rejection and internalizing problems in Western cultures (Rubin et al., 2009), but was historically linked to greater peer preference and competence in traditional China (Chen et al., 1995). In contemporary China, however, it is increasingly tied to adjustment difficulties (Liu et al., 2015).
- As social cognition matures, children’s judgments of peers become more reasoned, increasingly weighing context and the target’s characteristics (Grueneisen et al., 2023).
- Children tend to favor peers similar to themselves, so attributes such as gender and one’s own shyness can shape whom they prefer (Yang et al., 2021).

Research Question

- Whether Chinese children’s show low preferences towards peer shyness;
- Whether such preference could be influenced by social context, age, or self-shyness.

Result

- Shy peers were less preferred in friendship choice (See descriptive statistics in **Table 1**, both $p < .001$) and partner choice tasks (both $p < .001$) across all ages.
- Preschoolers sat farther from shy peers ($t = 2.61, p = .010$), adolescents did not ($t = 1.01, p = .312$).

Table 1. Friendship choice and seat selection, by age group and peer type.

Task	High-Shy	Low-Shy
Friendship Choice chosen as friend, % (n participants)		
Preschoolers	19.6% (20)	80.4% (82)
Adolescents	21.1% (26)	78.9% (97)
Seat Selection distance M (SD)		
Preschoolers	2.01 (0.69)	1.76 (0.78)
Adolescents	2.16 (1.00)	2.05 (0.99)
Partner Selection chosen as partner, % (n trials)		
Preschoolers	27.3% (167)	72.7% (445)
Adolescents	29.2% (285)	70.8% (691)

- Shyness significantly predicted shy peer friendship preference in adolescents ($p = .001$); the same trend in preschoolers was weaker and non-significant ($p = .22$). (**Figure. 2a**)
- Significant Age $\times$ Context interaction ($z = -4.39, p < .001$): adolescents rejected shy peers far more in high-social (7%) than low-social (42%) settings; preschoolers differentiated less (13% vs. 30%). (**Figure. 2b**)

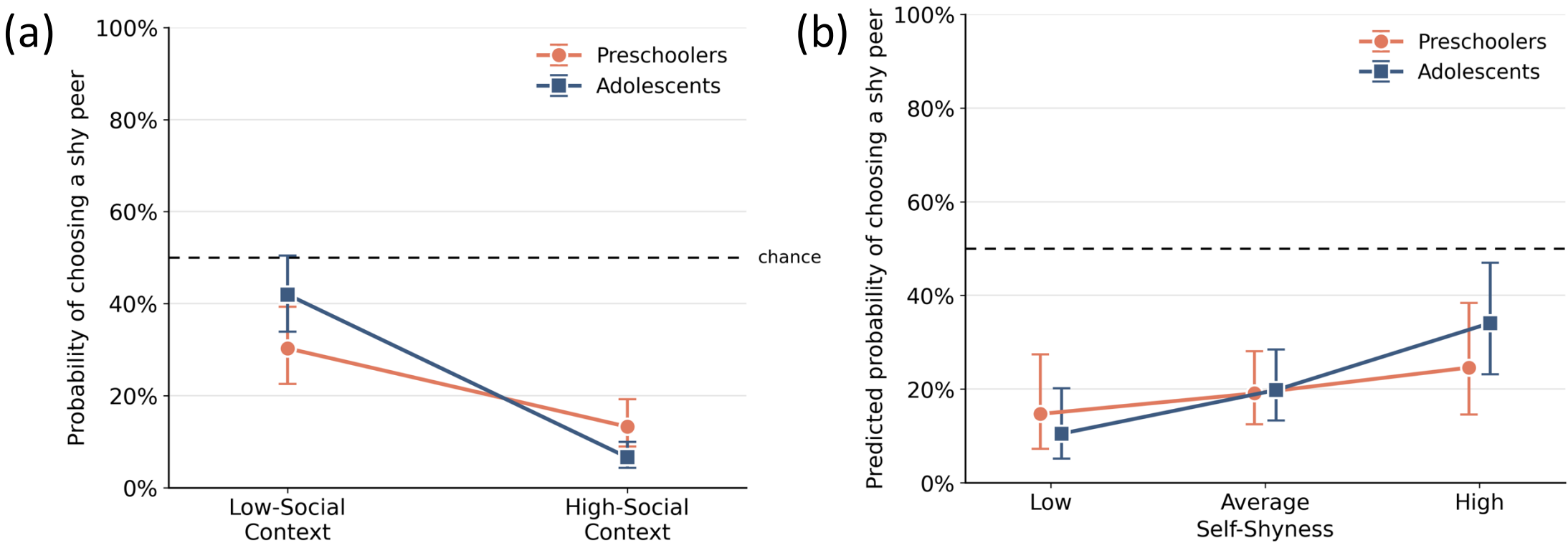


Figure 2. Age difference on children’s friendship choice (a) and partner choice (b)

Method

Participants

Preschoolers ($N = 102, M_{age} = 5.71$ years) and adolescents ($N = 123, M_{age} = 13.67$ years), recruited from public schools in Zhejiang Province, China.

Temperamental Shyness

- Preschoolers: Parent report Children’s Behavior Questionnaire (CBQ; Rothbart, 1996) shyness subscale
- Adolescents: Self-report Children’s Shyness Questionnaire (CSQ; Crozier, 1995)

Peer Preference Tasks

Preschoolers were tested individually in a quiet room; adolescents were tested in groups with paper-based materials. Materials were adapted to be developmentally appropriate for each age group.

Introduction of Hypothetical Peers

Four hypothetical peers were introduced to each participant: a High-Shy Boy, a High-Shy Girl, a Low-Shy Boy, and a Low-Shy Girl.

Seat Selection Task

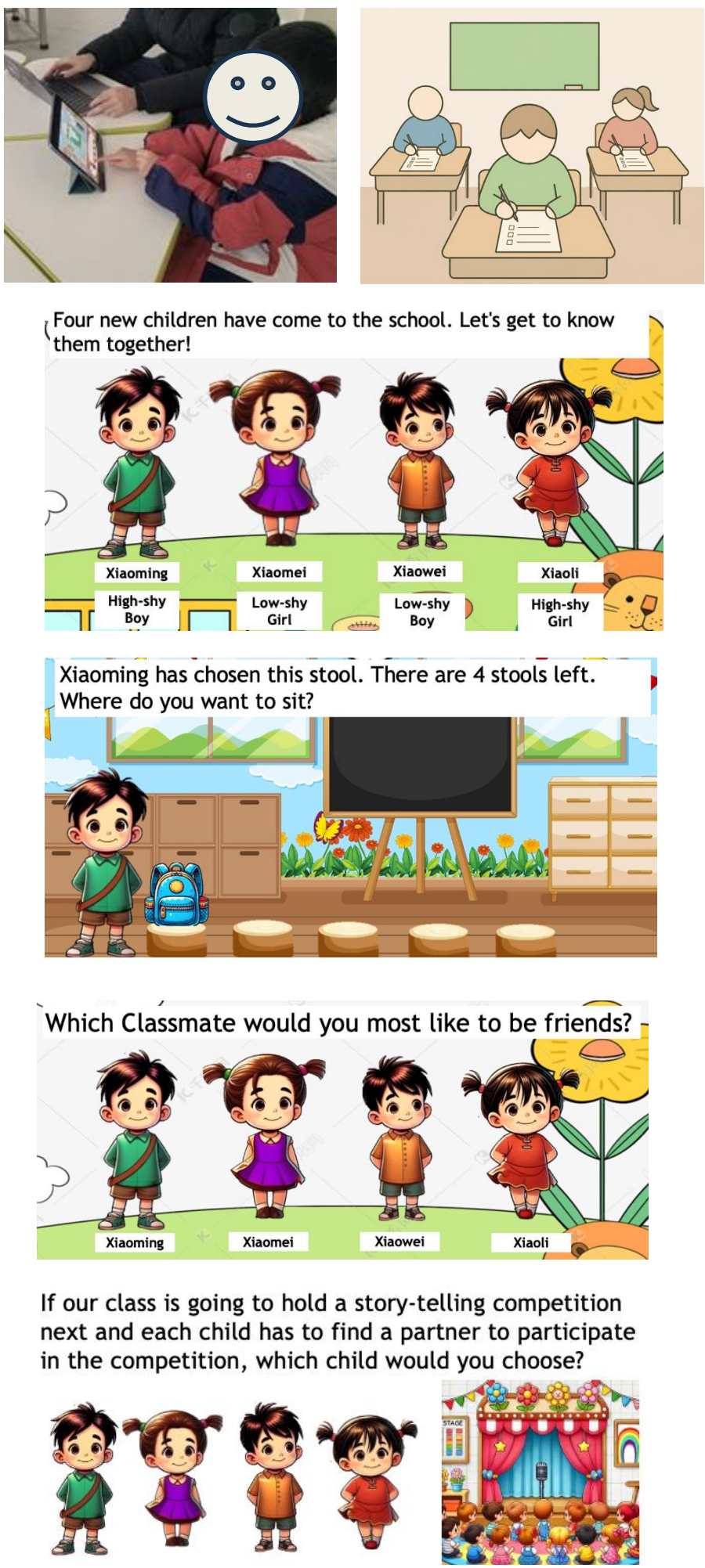
(Marinović et al., 2017) With each hypothetical peer seated on one side, participants chose one of four available seats.

Friendship Choice Task

Participants chose the peer they would most like to befriend.

Partner Choice Task

Participants selected a collaborative partner across high- vs. low-social scenarios (6 scenarios for preschoolers, 8 for adolescents).



Note. In Partner Selection, n represents number of trials (6 scenarios per preschooler, 8 per adolescent; 612 and 976 total trials respectively).

- Significant Age $\times$ Self-Shyness interaction ($z = 2.55, p = .011$) showed that higher self-shyness predicted greater preference for shy peers among adolescents but not preschoolers. Among adolescents, this similarity preference was significant in both low-social context ($p < .001$) and high-social context ($p = .019$); preschoolers showed no association in either context ($ps > .77$). (**Figure. 3**)

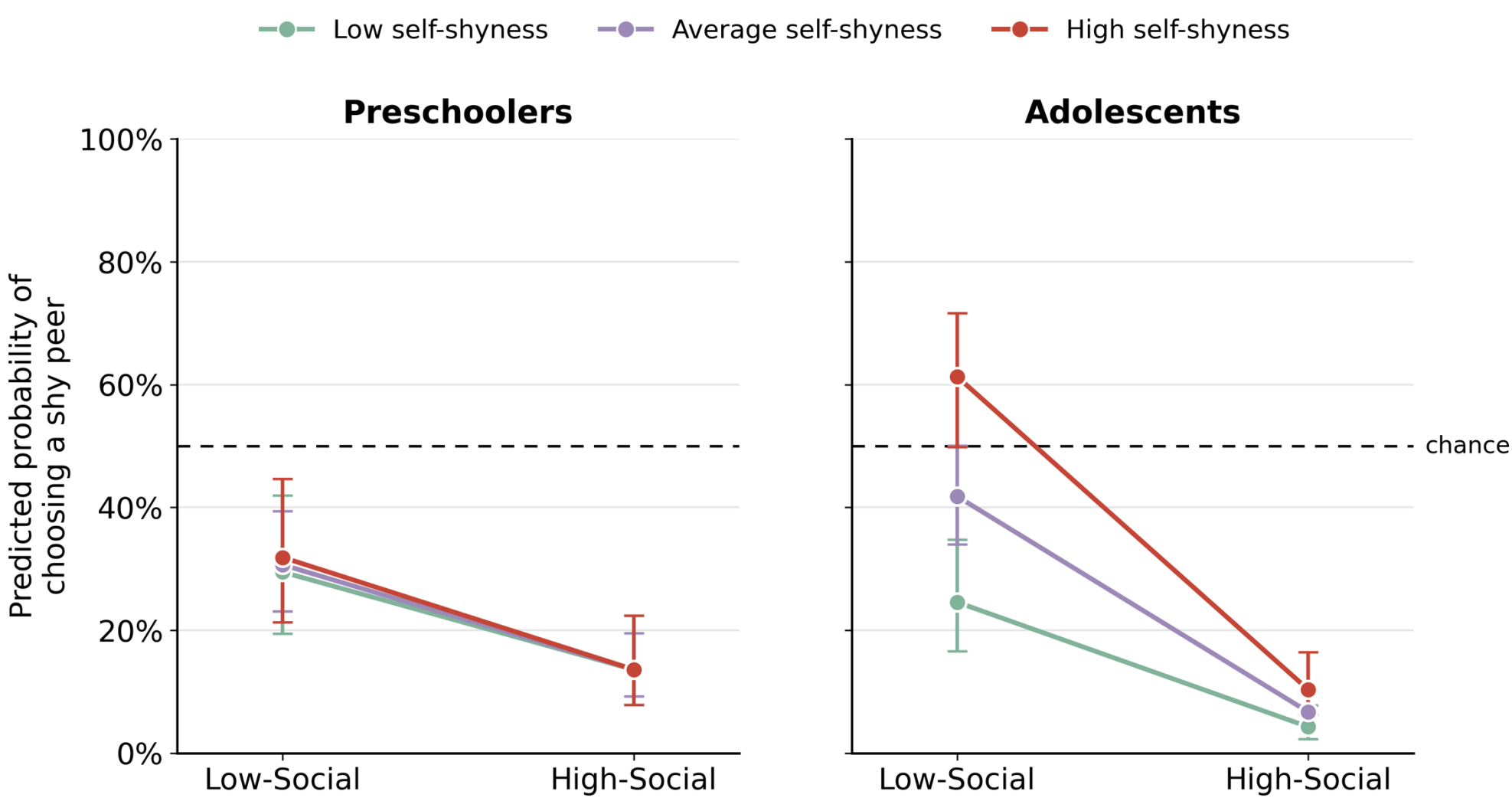


Figure 3. The effects on self-shyness, age and context on children’s partner choice

Conclusion

- Chinese children's low preference for shy peers emerges early and persists across development but becomes **increasingly context-sensitive** with age.
- In adolescence, this low preference is **moderated by children's own shyness**, with shy adolescents showing a stronger preference for shy peers.



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